



What Dropped This Week

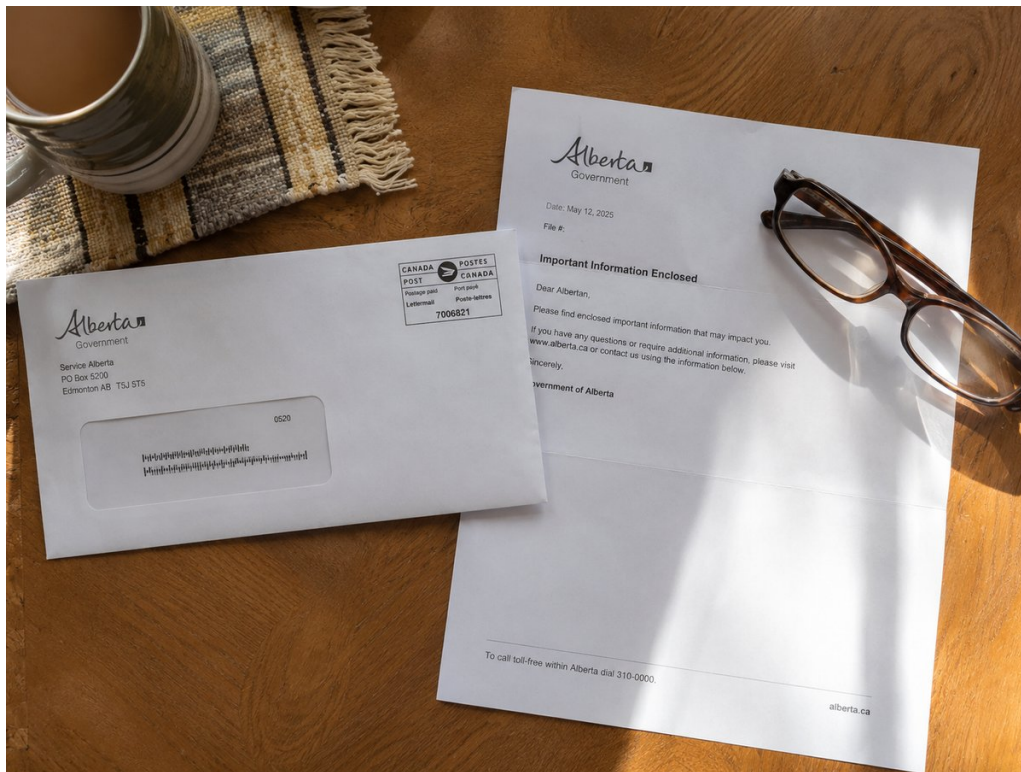
Plain Language Edition

What this is about: On May 12, 2026, the Government of Alberta released the rules for a new program called ADAP. The new rules will change how AISH works starting July 1, 2026. This guide explains what the new rules say, in plain language, and what they mean for you.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

St. Albert, Alberta | May 2026
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2. What got released on May 12, 2026



On May 12, 2026, the Government of Alberta put out a set of documents about the new Alberta Disability Assistance Program (ADAP). The main documents were:

- An **Order in Council**. That is a formal government decision that has the force of law. It approved the new rules for ADAP.
- A **Fact Sheet**. That is a summary of how the program is supposed to work, written for the public.
- Supporting documents about how the change will happen between July 2026 and January 2028.

Together, these documents say that ADAP will start on July 1, 2026. On that day, almost everyone on AISH will be moved into ADAP. People in ADAP will be able to ask to be moved back into AISH if they meet certain rules. After January 1, 2028, the temporary financial protection ends.

The short version: The rules for the new program are now official. They start in about six weeks. Most people on AISH will be moved into ADAP in July 2026 whether they choose to be or not.

3. The new program is called ADAP



ADAP stands for the **Alberta Disability Assistance Program**. It is the new program for Albertans with disabilities. It is replacing the way AISH works for many people.

AISH is not going away completely. The government says AISH will still be there for people who are seen as **permanently unable to work**. But the rules for who counts as permanently unable to work are changing.

ADAP is for people who the government sees as having a severe disability but who, in the government's view, can still work in some way. That includes people who:

- Have a disability but are not currently working
- Have a disability and work some hours but the government decides they could be working more
- Have a condition that comes and goes (called an episodic disability)
- Are waiting for the medical review panel to decide if they qualify for AISH

The government has the power to decide which program you go into. That decision is made by a medical review panel and a disability assistance adjudicator. We talk about how that decision gets made later in this guide.

4. The money: AISH stays, ADAP is \$200 less



Here are the new monthly payment amounts, starting July 2026:

Program	Maximum monthly payment
AISH	\$1,940
ADAP	\$1,740 (which is \$200 less)

The government says ADAP is lower because people on ADAP can supplement their income through work. The idea is that you make up the \$200 difference (and more) by working.

Both rates are supposed to go up each January 1 to keep up with the cost of living. The amount they go up by is decided by the government.

The transition rule: If you are on AISH right now, you will be moved to ADAP on July 1, 2026. The government has promised a **transition payment** that keeps your monthly income at the AISH rate of \$1,940 until December 31, 2027. After January 1, 2028, the transition payment ends. If you are still in ADAP at that point, your payment drops to \$1,740.

The federal CDB clawback:

Both rates include the federal Canada Disability Benefit of up to \$200/month. Alberta deducts the CDB dollar-for-dollar from your provincial payment, so the federal benefit does not add to your monthly income; it replaces \$200 of provincial spending.

5. Who gets put in ADAP vs. AISH



The decision about whether you go into AISH or ADAP comes down to what the government thinks about your ability to work.

AISH (the higher rate)

AISH is for people who the government considers **permanently unable to work**. The Fact Sheet gives examples like:

- People receiving palliative care
- People in continuing care because of severe medical conditions
- People with severe and profound disabilities needing ongoing care

A small amount of work (a few hours a week, called "community attachment") is allowed without losing AISH eligibility.

ADAP (the lower rate)

ADAP is for people the government decides have **some ability to work**. This can include people who:

- Are not currently working but the government thinks they could be
- Are working part-time but the government thinks they could work more
- Have episodic conditions where the future is unclear

If you start on ADAP and your condition gets worse, you can ask to be reassessed for AISH. A medical review panel makes that decision. Decisions by the medical review panel to deny AISH are **final and cannot be appealed**.

6. The transition: July 1, 2026 is the date



On July 1, 2026, almost everyone currently on AISH will be moved into ADAP. This is automatic. You do not have to fill out an application form. The government does it for you.

If you want to be reassessed for AISH after the move, you have from **July 1, 2026 to December 31, 2027** — 18 months — to ask for that reassessment.

How the reassessment works

- If your condition is severe and obvious (palliative care, profound disability), the disability assistance adjudicator can refer you to the medical review panel directly, without needing a new medical report.
- Everyone else needs a new **Disability Assistance Medical Report** from a registered medical professional. The medical professional must be on a pre-qualified roster, or be your primary care provider.
- After your medical report is reviewed, the medical review panel decides if you qualify for AISH. **If the panel says no, you stay in ADAP and cannot appeal that decision.**

On **January 1, 2028**, the transition ends. After that, anyone who has not been moved back into AISH is permanently in ADAP, with the \$1,740 monthly rate.

Key dates to remember:

July 1, 2026 — Everyone on AISH moves to ADAP (with transition payment).

December 31, 2027 — Last day to ask for reassessment back to AISH.

January 1, 2028 — Transition payments end. ADAP becomes permanent for everyone not moved back to AISH.

7. What happens to your health benefits



Health benefits include things like prescription drugs, ambulance rides, dental care, and eye care. Both AISH and ADAP say they include health benefits.

The Fact Sheet says ADAP recipients keep their health benefits even if they earn too much from work to qualify for the monthly payment. These continue until age 65.

However, the regulations also contain a number of changes to which specific items are covered, how prior authorization works, and what happens when a client is reassessed. The full forensic version of this document (*What Dropped This Week*) goes through the specific changes in detail. The short version: **you should not assume your current health benefit coverage carries over unchanged.** Check what your benefits will be under the new program before July 1, 2026.

What to do: If you have prescriptions, appointments, or ongoing care that depends on AISH health benefits, contact Alberta Supports before July 1, 2026 to ask specifically what will and will not be covered under ADAP for your situation.

8. The income exemption math



Income exemption means: how much you can earn from work before the government takes money off your monthly disability payment.

Under the new rules:

For ADAP (single person, no dependents):

- The first **\$350 a month** in employment income is fully exempt — it does not affect your payment.
- Above \$350, your payment is gradually reduced. By the time you reach about **\$45,000 a year** in employment income, the ADAP payment is fully clawed back.

For ADAP (with dependents):

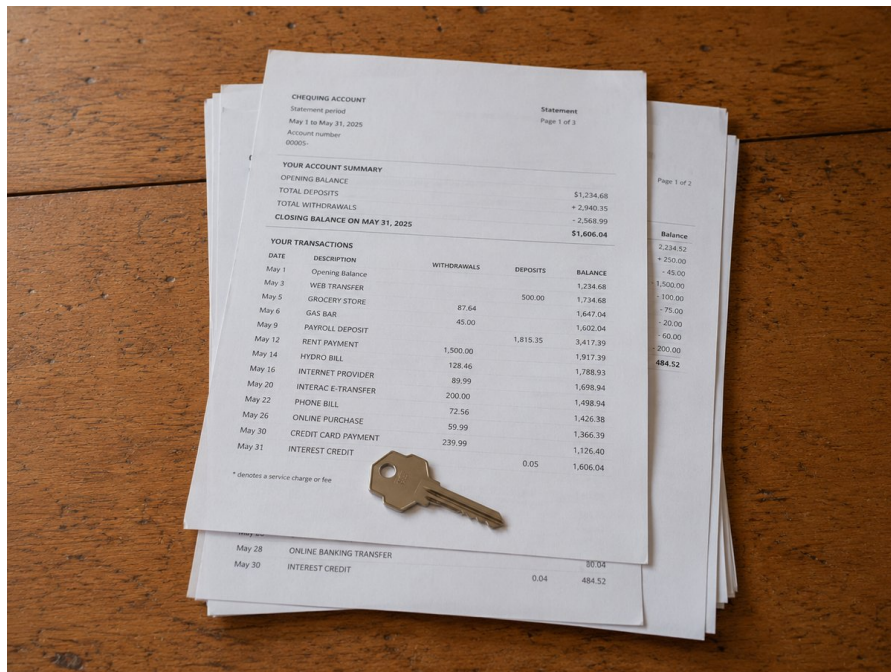
- The first **\$525 a month** is fully exempt.
- Full clawback happens at about **\$50,000 a year**.

For AISH:

- The first \$350 a month is fully exempt — same as ADAP.
- Above \$350, AISH deducts at 100%. So if you earn \$400 in a month, \$50 is deducted dollar-for-dollar from your AISH payment.
- AISH employment exemptions are being **reduced** from what they were before. The government's reasoning is that AISH is for people permanently unable to work, so the exemption does not need to encourage employment.

These exemption rules also apply to your spouse's income, with different numbers. If you have a working spouse, ask specifically how their income is treated.

9. The asset limit hasn't changed



To qualify for AISH or ADAP, the total value of certain assets you and your spouse own must be less than **\$100,000**. This number has not changed.

What does not count toward the \$100,000 limit

- A home you live in (or a quarter section if rural)
- A vehicle
- A second vehicle if it is adapted for a disability
- Clothing and reasonable household items
- A Registered Disability Savings Plan (RDSP)
- A trust

What does count toward the \$100,000 limit

- Cash
- Chequing and savings accounts
- Tax-Free Savings Accounts (TFSA's)
- Registered Retirement Savings Plans (RRSP's)
- Cash inheritances
- Recreational property or homes other than the one you live in
- Recreational vehicles

If you receive a one-time amount (an inheritance, a gift, money from selling a primary residence or vehicle, or an insurance payout), you have **365 days** to put it into an exempt asset. If you do not, it counts toward the \$100,000 limit and may affect your eligibility.

10. The government's claim: "Thoughtfully designed"



The May 12, 2026 Fact Sheet says ADAP was **“thoughtfully designed based on input from Albertans with disabilities.”** This is one of five statements the government makes about ADAP that we think deserves a closer look.

What is true

The government did run a consultation. The Discussion Guide was real. People did respond to it. Some of what the public said is reflected in the program. For example, the idea of keeping health benefits after returning to work was a common request, and that is in ADAP.

What is in question

We do not have access to the full record of what people said in the consultation. The government has not released the survey responses. Multiple advocacy organizations, including **Inclusion Alberta**, publicly raised concerns about the proposed design during the consultation window. Those concerns included:

- The ADAP rate being lower than AISH could push people into deeper poverty
- The employment focus could push people with serious disabilities into unsafe work situations
- The reassessment process places the burden of proof on the disabled person

The program that was released on May 12, 2026 still has all of those features. Whether that means the consultation input was carefully weighed and rejected, or whether the design was already settled before the consultation began, is a question that depends on records the government has not made public.

11. The government's claim: "Empowering employment"



The government says ADAP will **empower Albertans with disabilities to pursue fulfilling job opportunities**. The Fact Sheet talks about support to gain skills, find work, and stay employed.

What is true

The government has set aside \$250 million for ADAP employment supports. There are programs for job training, supported employment, and accommodations. These are real services that some people will benefit from.

What is in question

The Alberta unemployment rate for people with disabilities is significantly higher than the rate for non-disabled people. Most research shows that the barrier to employment is not the disabled person's motivation or willingness to work — it is employer attitudes, accessibility of workplaces, and the cost of accommodations.

ADAP's design puts the work of getting employed on the disabled person. It assumes employment is available and accessible. For Albertans who have tried and tried to get hired, that assumption feels like blame.

The Fact Sheet also does not include any commitment to penalize employers who discriminate. It funds supports for the disabled person, but does not address the people doing the hiring.

12. The government's claim: "Severe disability"



The government says ADAP is for people with **severe disabilities who can still work in some way**.

The definition of severe disability used to allow people with serious conditions to qualify for AISH whether they were able to work or not. Under the new rules, the test is split:

- If the government's decision-makers think your condition is permanent and you cannot work at all, you may go into AISH.
- If they think your condition is severe but you could work some amount, you go into ADAP — with \$200/month less and the expectation of employment activity.

The line between "cannot work" and "could work some amount" is being drawn by a medical review panel. The people making that decision are doctors and other medical professionals. They are looking at your medical record and deciding what category you fall into.

What this means in practice: Two people with the same diagnosis can end up in different programs, with different payment amounts, based on how the medical review panel interprets their ability to work. The panel's decisions to deny AISH cannot be appealed.

13. The government's claim: "A promise to Albertans"



Government communications about ADAP have repeatedly used language about a **promise to improve supports** for Albertans with disabilities.

Things in the May 12 release that look like improvement

- Health benefits continue when someone returns to work
- \$250 million in additional employment supports
- A larger income exemption while working (for some clients)

Things in the May 12 release that do not look like improvement

- ADAP monthly payment is \$200/month lower than AISH (\$2,400/year less)
- Reduced employment exemption for people who stay on AISH
- Loss of appeal rights for AISH denials by the new medical review panel
- Transition protection only lasts 18 months; after January 2028, those moved to ADAP lose the protected rate
- Tighter medical eligibility test for AISH

Whether the May 12 release improves things on balance depends on which group of clients you are looking at. For some, the new program is an improvement. For many, it is a cut. The Fact Sheet emphasizes the first group. The full record shows the second group is much larger.

14. The government's claim: "Public engagement concluded"



The government says public engagement on ADAP **concluded in March 2026**, and that **thousands of Albertans participated** in the consultation.

The Discussion Guide is real. The consultation did happen. But the engagement page that documents the consultation has been changed in ways that should be on the public record.

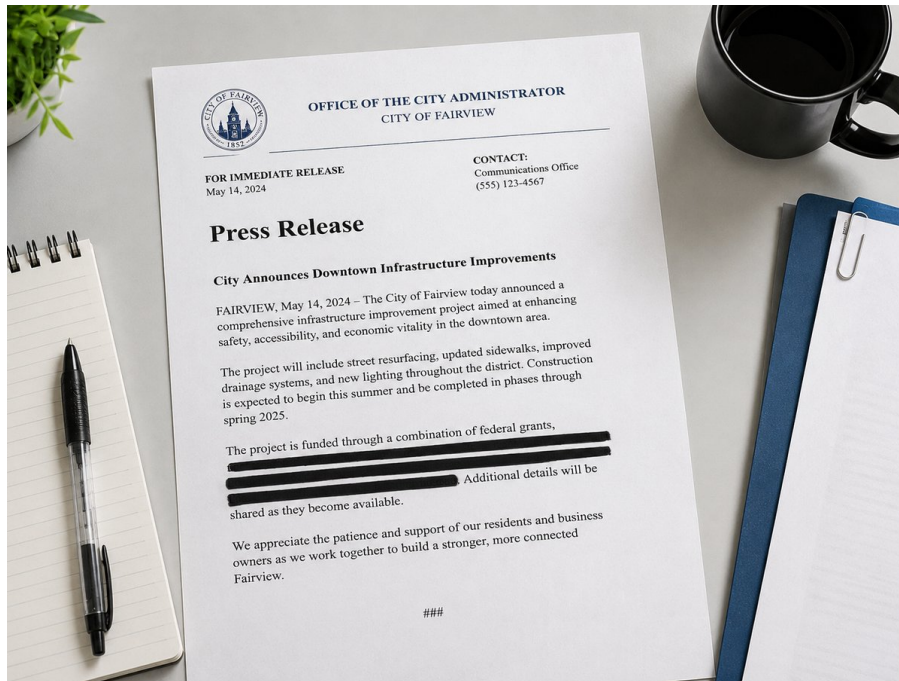
What we found about the engagement page

- The page was rewritten from an active consultation portal to a look-back archive within seven days of consultation closing
- The page's stated survey end date was quietly changed from September 12 (the date in the Discussion Guide and on the page during the consultation) to September 14, 2025
- The page sat unchanged for seven months after the rewrite, through Bill 12 being tabled, Bill 12 passing, and the March 2026 budget announcement — none of which were added to the page
- Since April 12, 2026, the page has been blocked from being archived by the Wayback Machine, so changes after that date cannot be tracked

The full record: We made a separate document called *The Engagement Page Record: A Forensic Timeline* that goes through everything we found in detail. There is also a plain-language version. Both are available from the campaign.

The government may have good reasons for some of these changes. But the public has not been told what those reasons are. And the page as it exists today is not the page that existed during the consultation it documents.

15. What the May 12 release does not say



Sometimes what is missing from a government release is as important as what is in it. The May 12, 2026 ADAP release does not include:

- **An automatic cost-of-living adjustment formula.** The regulations say the monthly amount “will be adjusted annually” but do not say by how much, or based on what measure. The government decides each year.
- **Protection for current AISH recipients who fail the new medical test.** If you are on AISH today and the medical review panel decides you do not meet the new criteria, you go to ADAP. The May 12 release does not include a grandfather clause for people who qualified under the old rules.
- **Appeal rights for the medical review panel.** Decisions by the AISH medical review panel to deny AISH eligibility cannot be appealed. There is no mention of how to challenge a panel decision if it appears to have been made in error.
- **A guaranteed transition period beyond 18 months.** The transition payment ends January 1, 2028 regardless of whether a person has been reassessed by then. There is no extension clause.
- **Specific commitments about wait times for medical review panel decisions.** The May 12 documents do not say how long an applicant has to wait between filing for AISH reassessment and receiving a decision.
- **Detailed lists of what is no longer covered under health benefits.** The Fact Sheet talks about health benefits in general terms but does not enumerate specific exclusions.

These gaps matter because they are decisions that get made later, outside of public attention, through internal administrative decisions.

16. The bigger picture: where this fits



ADAP is not happening in isolation. It is one part of a wider set of changes to how Alberta supports vulnerable people. The Alberta Disability System Breakdown campaign documents this wider context.

Compassionate Intervention Act

Alberta has also passed the Compassionate Intervention Act, which allows for involuntary addiction treatment. This costs about \$180 million and includes 300 secure treatment beds in Edmonton and Calgary, planned to be operational by 2029. Compassionate Intervention applies to people in crisis, which can include disabled people in poverty.

Service-provider funding changes

While direct income supports to disabled Albertans are being held or reduced, government funding to some organizations that serve those same Albertans has increased substantially. The Mustard Seed Society, for example, received a 308% increase in Government of Alberta funding between fiscal 2019 and fiscal 2025.

Why these matter together

When direct supports to disabled people decrease while indirect supports (shelters, treatment beds, service providers) increase, the result is a shift in how people are kept alive. Instead of having enough money to live independently, people are pushed into systems that manage them. This is a policy shift, not a coincidence.

17. What you can do



If you are on AISH or have a family member on AISH, here are some things you can do before July 1, 2026.

Document your situation

If you have ever struggled to find work because of disability or discrimination, write it down. Save the letters, the rejection emails, the doctors' notes. The Alberta Disability System Breakdown has fillable forms for documenting these stories. Email albertadisabilitybreakdown@outlook.com for templates.

Call Alberta Supports

Before July 1, contact Alberta Supports specifically: (1) What will my situation look like under ADAP? (2) What health benefits stay and what changes? (3) What is the process if I want to be reassessed for AISH? Write down the answers.

Contact your MLA

Your Member of the Legislative Assembly represents you in Edmonton. They can ask the Minister of Assisted Living and Social Services for clarification on questions about how ADAP will work for someone with your specific circumstances.

Contact your MP

Your federal Member of Parliament can raise the issue in the House of Commons. The Canada Disability Benefit and the Provincial-Federal social assistance framework are federal-provincial issues. Federal attention matters.

Share these documents

Free to share. Free to print. Free to forward. The campaign's purpose is to make sure people know what is happening before it happens.

Come to the steps

Updates about protests, rallies, and public actions are shared through the Alberta Disability System Breakdown Facebook group. You do not need any qualifications to come. You just need to be there.

18. How to verify what is in this document



Everything in this guide comes from public documents. You can check any of it yourself.

The Order in Council and ADAP Fact Sheet

- Available on the Government of Alberta website. Search for “ADAP Fact Sheet” or “Alberta Disability Assistance Program regulations.”
- The Order in Council is published in the official Alberta Gazette.

The Discussion Guide

- Search alberta.ca for “Transforming Disability Income Assistance Discussion Guide.” Both regular and large-print versions are still available.

The engagement page record

- The current live page is at alberta.ca/alberta-disability-assistance-program-engagement.
- Older versions of the page are at web.archive.org. Paste the page address into the Wayback Machine search bar.

Bill 12

- Bill 12 (Financial Statutes Amendment Act, No. 2) was tabled November 25, 2025 and passed December 9, 2025. Hansard records of the debate are available on the Legislative Assembly of Alberta website.

Service provider funding records

- Provincial grant awards are published in the Alberta Public Accounts (annual financial statements) and individual organization annual reports.

19. Sources and closing



This plain-language guide is a companion to the full document, **What Dropped This Week: The May 12, 2026 ADAP-to-AISH Release — An Information Analysis**, available from the Alberta Disability System Breakdown campaign. The full version goes through the regulations in detail and includes citations to every government document referenced.

Where the information comes from

- Government of Alberta, ADAP Fact Sheet, May 12, 2026
- Government of Alberta, Alberta Disability Assistance Program regulations and Order in Council, May 12, 2026
- Government of Alberta, Transforming Disability Income Assistance in Alberta Discussion Guide, August 2025
- Bill 12 (Financial Statutes Amendment Act, No. 2), Hansard records, November-December 2025
- Government of Alberta, Budget 2026 documents, March 24, 2026
- Alberta Public Accounts, multiple fiscal years (service provider funding data)
- Wayback Machine snapshots of the alberta.ca engagement page, August 2025 to April 2026 (engagement page record)

Companion documents from this campaign

- *What Dropped This Week: An Information Analysis* — full version of this PLG
- *The Engagement Page Record: A Forensic Timeline* — full version of the engagement page finding
- *The Engagement Page Record: Plain Language Edition* — plain language version of the engagement record

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